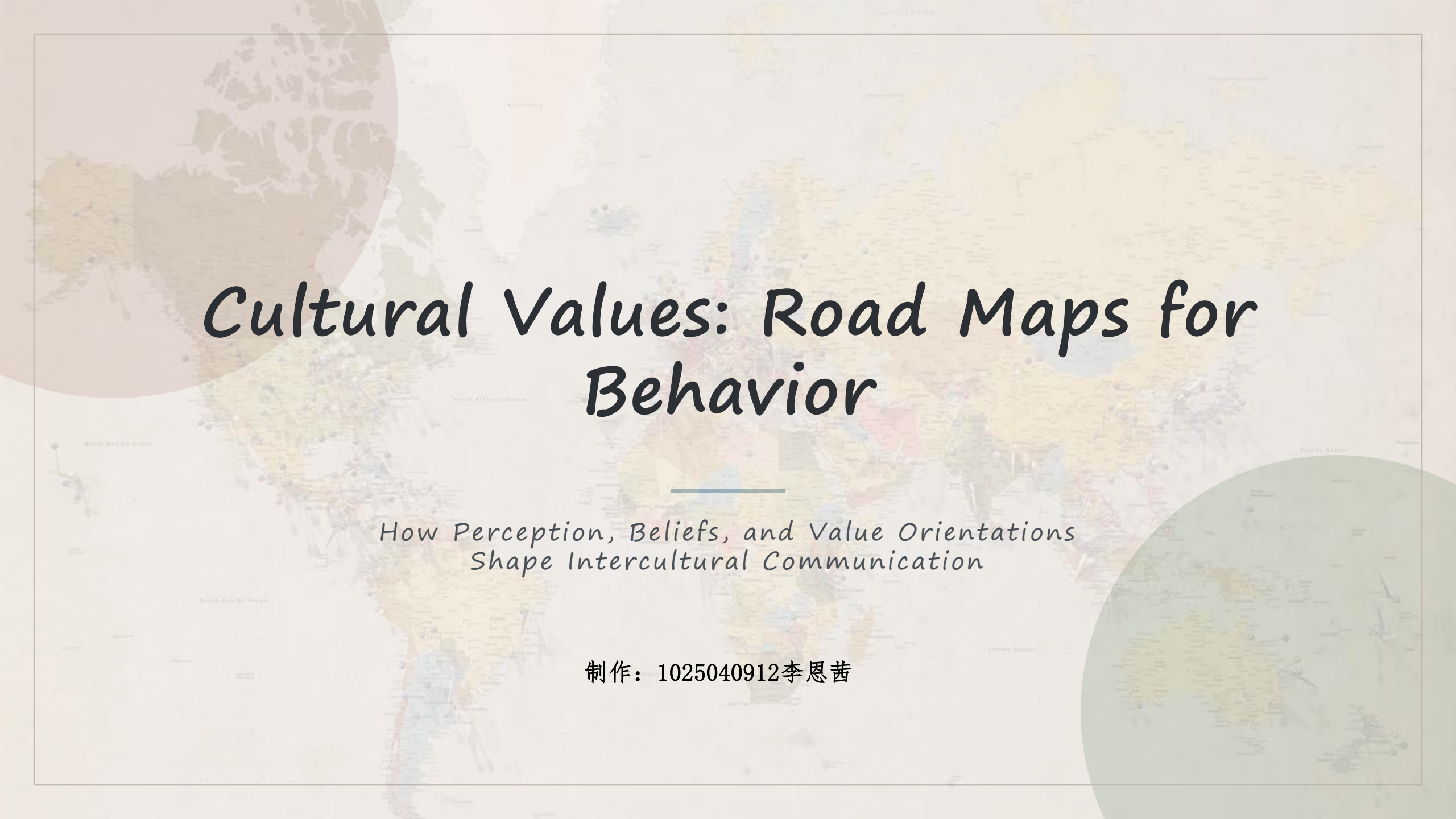


A world map in a light, muted color palette serves as the background. Two large, semi-transparent circles are overlaid on the map: a light pink one on the left and a light green one on the right. The title text is centered over the map.

Cultural Values: Road Maps for Behavior

*How Perception, Beliefs, and Value Orientations
Shape Intercultural Communication*

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Perception: The Filter of Reality

Perception is the process of selecting, organizing, and interpreting information.

It helps people make sense of the world, but it is never completely objective. Different cultural backgrounds create different "filters" for the same event.

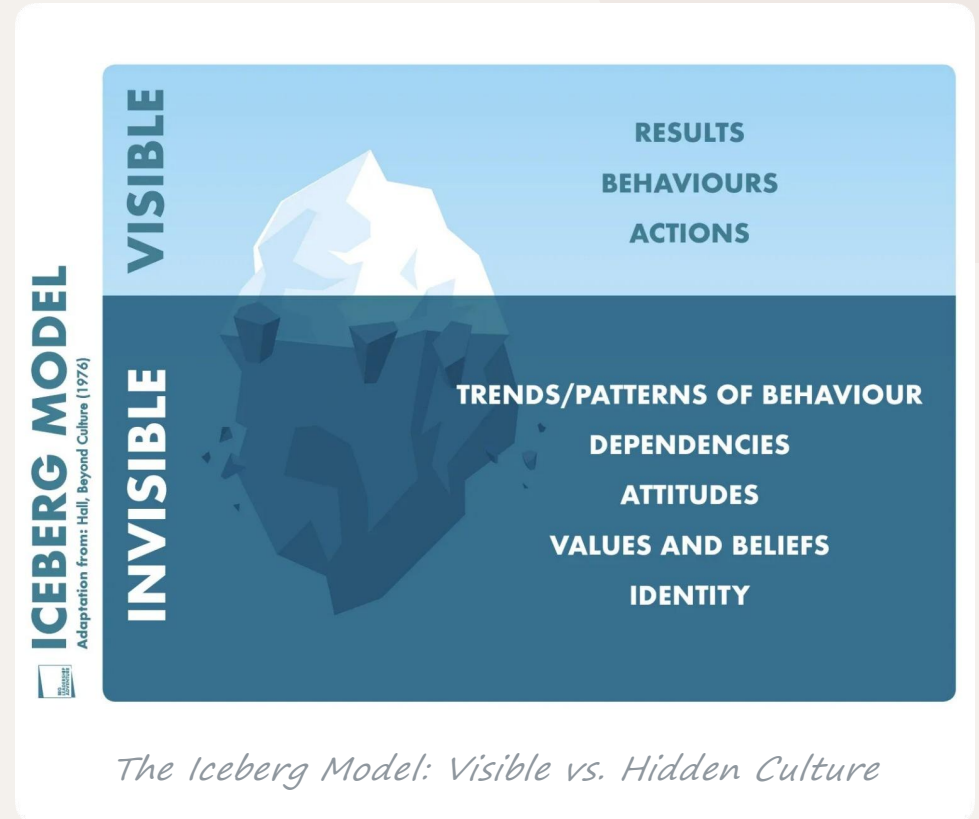


Real-World Example

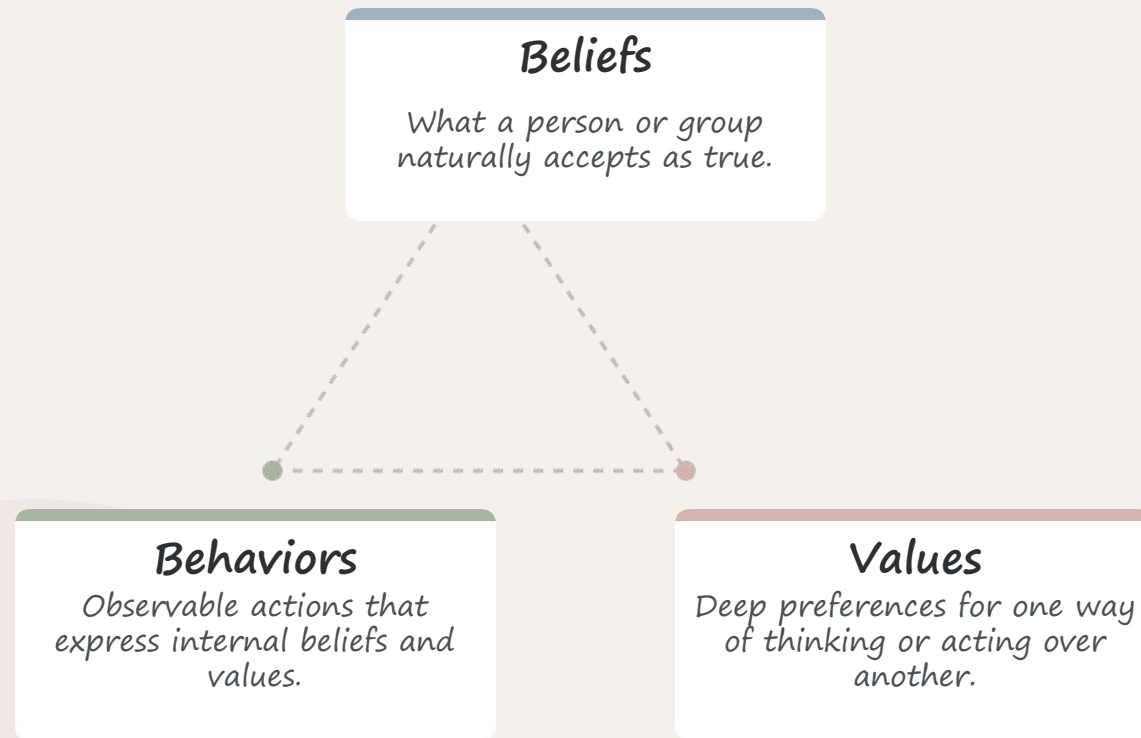
*In American business meetings, direct debate may be interpreted as **engagement**; in many East Asian settings, the same behavior may be read as too **confrontational**.*

Five Characteristics of Perception

-  **Selective:** We focus on certain stimuli and naturally ignore others.
-  **Learned:** Experience teaches us what to notice and how to interpret it.
-  **Culturally determined:** Culture sets the norms for what counts as meaningful.
-  **Consistent:** Once formed, our existing perceptions strongly resist change.
-  **Inaccurate / subjective:** Perception can easily distort objective reality.



Beliefs, Values, and Behaviors: The Core Triangle



💎 Applied Example: Beauty Ideals



Western Contexts

Tanning is often associated with leisure, health, and vitality, leading to values and behaviors centered around sunbathing.



Asian Contexts

Light skin is frequently tied to care, protection, and professionalism, resulting in behaviors like using sun umbrellas and sunscreen.

Cultural Patterns as Value Orientations



Cultural Patterns serve as an umbrella term for the dominant value tendencies of a particular culture.

They provide a highly useful map for comparing communication styles, identifying social expectations, and anticipating cultural norms.



Crucial Caution

These patterns describe shared cultural tendencies, but they do not describe every individual within a culture. They are helpful navigational tools rather than rigid stereotypes.

Kohls' U.S. Values and Cultural Contrasts

Dominant U.S. Values

- 🔑 Personal control over environment
- ⚡ Change and action
- 🕒 Time control and schedules
- ⚖️ Equality and egalitarianism
- 👤 Individualism and privacy

VS

Counterpart Values

- ☁️ Fate and destiny
- 🏰 Tradition and stability
- 💬 Human interaction over time
- 🏛️ Hierarchy and status
- 👥 Group welfare and belonging

Real-World Contrasts

Nike's **"Just Do It"** slogan is a classic reflection of an action-oriented culture that highly values personal control and agency.

The everyday use of **"Inshallah"** (*if God wills*) in many cultures reflects a stronger acceptance of fate and destiny in planning.

Hall's High-Context vs. Low-Context Communication

High-Context Orientations

- 🗨️ Meaning is embedded in situation
- 👥 Heavy reliance on relationships
- 👁️ Nonverbal cues carry significant weight
- 💬 Communication is often indirect
- 🕊️ Harmony prioritized over directness

VS

Low-Context Orientations

- 📄 Meaning is carried by explicit words
- 👤 Less reliance on shared background
- 🔊 Verbal clarity is highly valued
- ➔ Communication is direct and precise
- ⌚ Efficiency and facts are prioritized

Workplace Communication Contrasts

A high-context refusal may be phrased softly and indirectly: "That may be challenging right now..." rather than a direct "no" to protect mutual face.

A low-context email is typically explicit and straightforward, directly asking for "the bottom line by EOD" to ensure maximum efficiency and clarity.

Hofstede: Individualism vs. Collectivism

Independent Self

Interdependent Self

Individualism

- Culture shapes an "I" consciousness
- Emphasis on *personal rights and privacy*
- Self-expression and autonomy are prioritized

Collectivism

- Culture shapes a "We" consciousness
- Emphasis on *harmony and saving face*
- Loyalty and group interests come first



Real-World Context: Crisis Response

After the **2011 Japan earthquake**, Reuters reported widespread public stoicism and self-restraint. This behavior powerfully illustrates **collective social discipline**—where preserving group harmony, order, and mutual support takes precedence over individual expressions of distress.

Hofstede: Uncertainty Avoidance & Power Distance

Low UA

High UA

Low PD

High PD



Uncertainty Avoidance (UA)

- Measures how comfortable people are with **ambiguity and risk**
- High-UA cultures prefer **rules, structure, and predictability**
- Low-UA cultures embrace flexibility and unusual ideas



Power Distance (PD)

- Acceptance of **inequality in authority and status**
- High-PD cultures respect strict **hierarchy and deference**
- Low-PD cultures expect egalitarianism and shared power



Real-World Context: Procedures & Equality

Germany and Japan (High-UA) rely heavily on detailed procedures and punctuality to minimize operational uncertainty. Conversely, **Starbucks'** 2012 initiative to write customers' first names on cups reflects a Low-PD service style, actively breaking down formal barriers to foster an **egalitarian** social environment.

Hofstede: Masculinity vs. Femininity

A cultural dimension reflecting social values, not biological sex

Masculinity Orientation

- 🏆 High value on competition
- 📈 Focus on achievement & success
- 🗣️ Assertiveness is expected
- 💎 Material rewards indicate status

VS

Femininity Orientation

- 🤝 Care for the weak and vulnerable
- 🙇 Modesty and humility valued
- ❤️ Quality of life over material gain
- ⚖️ Strong social support systems



Real-World Example

Nordic parental leave systems (especially in **Norway and Sweden**) reflect a strong cultural commitment to the "Femininity" pole. These societies emphasize shared caregiving, work-life balance, and well-being over relentless career competition.

Hofstede: Long-Term vs. Short-Term Orientation

Future Focus

Immediate Focus

Long-Term Orientation

- Culture emphasizes *perseverance and thrift*
- Focus on *deferred rewards* and future gains
- Strategic planning and adaptability over time

Short-Term Orientation

- Culture emphasizes *tradition and stability*
- Focus on fulfilling *immediate obligations*
- Preference for quick, highly visible results



Real-World Context: Institutional Investment

Organizations with a **long-term orientation** frequently tolerate short-term sacrifices—such as reduced quarterly profits to fund intensive R&D or employee training—to secure sustainable **future gains**. Conversely, short-term-oriented institutions heavily optimize for immediate quarterly outcomes and rapid returns.

Minkov's Cultural Dimensions

Industry vs. Indulgence



Industry (Restraint)

Prioritizes hard work, duty, and strict social discipline. Gratification is tightly regulated.



Indulgence

Emphasizes enjoyment, leisure time, freedom of expression, and overall life satisfaction.

Monumentalism vs. Flexumility



Monumentalism

Values a stable identity, personal pride, and holding strong, unwavering absolute beliefs.



Flexumility

Focuses on adaptability, humility, and the willingness to learn, adjust, and change oneself.

Cultural Regulation Examples

Indulgent societies tend to grant individuals more freedom to enjoy life, express desires, and value leisure time as a core part of well-being.

Restrained societies tightly regulate gratification through strict social norms, prioritizing collective duty and discipline over personal joy.

Gelfand: Tight vs. Loose Cultures

Tight Cultures

- 🔗 Strong social norms
- 🚫 Low tolerance for deviant behavior
- 🛡️ High social discipline
- 📋 Clear expectations and rules
- 🔪 Sanctions for non-compliance

VS

Loose Cultures

- 🌊 Weaker social norms
- 👉 Tolerance for unusual behavior
- 🕊️ Relaxed social discipline
- 🔲 Flexibility in applying rules
- 🎲 Broader range of acceptable behavior

Real-World Evidence

A 33-nation study (Gelfand et al., 2011) found tight cultures often have histories of severe ecological or historical threats.

During the pandemic response, tight cultures generally showed more coordinated behaviors and better compliance with restrictions.



Ting-Toomey: Face and Facework

Face is a person's public self-image and social dignity.

Facework refers to the communicative actions used to maintain, defend, or protect that image.

These actions can be directed at self-face, other-face, or mutual-face, deeply guiding intercultural interactions.



Conflict Resolution Example

*In face-sensitive settings, direct public criticism is avoided to protect another person's dignity. **Private correction** is often preferred to preserve harmony.*



Cultural Values: A Practical Map



1. Perception is Filtered

Reality is never completely objective. Cultural backgrounds act as powerful lenses that selectively organize and interpret what we see.



2. The Core Triangle

Beliefs shape our enduring values, which in turn manifest as observable communication behaviors and norms across different societies.



3. Five Key Cultural Frameworks

Hall: High & Low Context

Hofstede: Cultural Dimensions

Minkov: Indulgence & Monumentalism

Gelfand: Tight & Loose Cultures

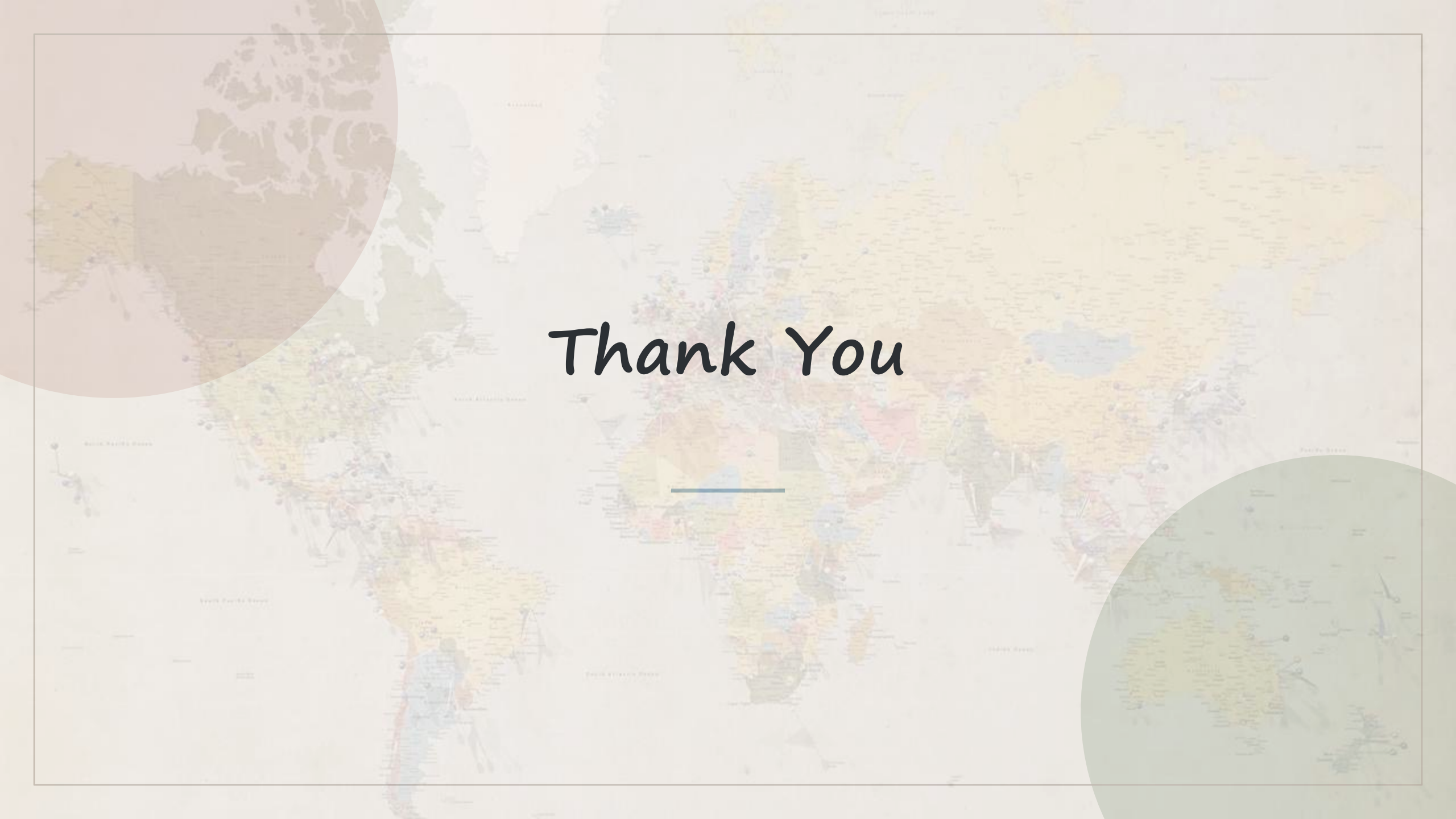
Ting-Toomey: Face & Facework



Navigating Intercultural Spaces

These models are not absolute rules. They are powerful, practical tools.

By using them as road maps, we can reduce misunderstanding, build empathy, and systematically improve our intercultural competence.



Thank You
